



Blinkers on: Two-time Olympic medallist Sindhu, 28, is focused on getting it right at the 2024 Paris Olympics. PTI

right at the 2024 Paris Olympics. She expects Santoso to turn her fortunes around at the Prakash Padukone Academy in Bengaluru.

For those curious about Saina Nehwal, the former World No. 1 was placed 30th on the ranking list at the start of 2023. She finished the year at a distant 97. She played a total of nine singles matches spread over six tournaments and managed to win only three first-round matches. In fact, when Saina was still active, with Sindhu too making giant strides, the two augmented India's strength in women's singles in premier competitions. During those days, India lacked a third player of substance. At present, finding even a second player with some decent playing strength appears to be a luxury, so dismal is the scenario for women's singles in the country.

PRESENT QUALITY OF THE CREAMY LAYER OF INDIA IN SINGLES, WOMEN'S DOUBLES, AND MIXED DOUBLES IS A CONCERN

The young women's doubles combination of Treasa Jolly and Gayatri Gopi Chand started 2023 at 16 and finished at 19. In contrast, the vastly experienced doubles specialist Ashwini Ponnappa and her young partner Tanisha Crasto came together in May and had a ranking of 112 in the doubles rankings. If they ended the year at an impressive 24th, it was mainly due to the way they finished the season. They reached the final of three successive events at home after winning the Abu Dhabi Masters. They lost in the finals of the Syed Modi India International and Odisha Masters, but in between, they won the

Guwahati Masters. As a result, two women's pairs will be vying for a qualifying spot in the Olympics. In reality, barring the exploits of Chirag and Satwik and hopes of a strong comeback from Sindhu, not much is expected from the younger crop in 2024. Prannoy and Lakshya will again be the ones to watch out for in men's singles. But the present quality of the creamy layer of India in singles, women's doubles, and mixed doubles continues to be a source of worry. When it comes to champion-building, the year 2024 should serve as a great reality-check on where the sport is headed in the country.